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Internship

At

Digital Empowerment Foundation

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Abstract

This report documents my internship with the Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) at Solapur, Maharashtra, during May 2026. Working under the Digikargha programme DEF's initiative for artisan empowerment through digital tools I spent four weeks with the handloom weaver communities of Solapur: producers of the GI-tagged Solapur Chaddar, terry towels, and sarees. My work combined digital literacy training across multiple locations, a KoBoToolbox baseline survey, in-depth interviews with weavers and powerloom workers, home visits to handloom sari workers, and co-authoring a nine-chapter coffee table book on Solapur's handloom heritage. I also accompanied a Suchna-preneur on a grassroots digital service delivery visit and participated in a review meeting with DEF's State Lead. Over the month I interacted directly with over 330 people. The baseline survey found that only 40% of weavers had heard of the GI tag on their own product, and awareness was concentrated almost entirely among workers aged 45 and above. This report reflects on what I learned, where theory held and where it did not, and what the programme achieves within the structural conditions of Solapur's textile economy.

Acknowledgements

I am grateful to DEF for placing their trust in me as a field intern, and to the weaver families, powerloom workers, cooperative members, and factory owners of Solapur who gave me their time often during working hours they could not afford to lose. My organisational mentor and DEF's State Lead shaped how I understood the programme. My faculty supervisor at SDS, TISS gave me the academic grounding to make sense of what I was observing. And the weavers themselves including the Padmashali families from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, and the women sari workers I visited at home were far more patient with my questions than I had any right to expect.

1. Introduction

1.1 Why DEF, Why Solapur

Development Studies keeps pushing you toward a question easier to ask in a seminar room than answer in the field: what does development actually look like when it reaches a community? Not the policy design, not the programme logic the specific moment when an intervention meets a person with a loom and a phone and concerns no project document anticipated.

I chose DEF because it works at that junction. It does not build roads or distribute rations. It works on something harder to measure whether people excluded from the digital economy can be brought into it in a way that actually improves their lives. That question sits at the centre of what I have been studying: how structural exclusion is reproduced, what interventions can shift it, and where they hit their limits.

Solapur added a personal dimension. I had already spent time there on a documentation project and left with questions I could not answer from the outside. The weavers I met produced internationally traded goods a Solapur Chaddar carries a GI tag and sells from Mumbai to the Middle East yet most families were on piece-rate wages, without a safety net, without a union with real bargaining power, and with almost no visibility into what their work was worth. That disconnect did not sit easily with me. The internship was an attempt to go back with better tools and a clearer set of questions.

1.2 Relevance to My Academic Background

My coursework at TISS moved between the theoretical political economy, development theory, urban informality, livelihoods and the methodological, particularly qualitative and mixed-methods research. Both were directly relevant in Solapur. But the internship tested things coursework cannot prepare you for: building trust with a stranger in thirty minutes, interviewing someone whose first language is a dialect you half-understand, facilitating a workshop for participants ranging from a twenty-year-old with Instagram to a sixty-year-old who has never used a touchscreen.

2. About the Organisation

2.1 Digital Empowerment Foundation

DEF was established in 2002 and operates across 28+ states, covering digital literacy, community media, e-governance facilitation, and livelihood support consistently focused on communities overlooked in mainstream digital policy: rural artisans, tribal populations, urban poor, women in informal work. My placement was with DEF's Solapur operations under the Digikargha programme.

2.2 The Digikargha Programme

Digikargha runs on three things: digital literacy training, e-commerce integration through Amazon Karigar, Flipkart Samarth, and awareness work around GI tags. The logic is defensible if weavers understand their GI certification, know how to list a product online, and can navigate digital payments, they gain at least the possibility of reaching buyers directly. The Chaddar has real market demand. What is missing is the producer-side infrastructure: financial access, digital confidence, and collective organisation strong enough to negotiate rather than simply accept terms.

2.3 The Suchna-preneur Model

Suchna-preneurs are community-level digital service providers a last-mile bridge between communities and the digital economy. Accompanying one on a field visit showed me what sustainable digital inclusion looks like beyond a one-time workshop: capacity embedded in the community rather than imported periodically from outside.

3. Work Done During the Internship

3.1 Overview

My four weeks fell into four overlapping streams: field research, digital literacy training, coffee table book development, and stakeholder engagement. Most days combined at least two. The plan changed regularly because fieldwork rarely accommodates calendars. Learning to work within that rather than against it was itself part of the internship.

3.2 Field Research: Weeks One and Two

The first two weeks were an immersion phase visiting production units, conducting interviews, building enough presence that people would talk honestly rather than give me the answers they thought I wanted. The powerloom environment was a useful contrast to handloom: more mechanised, higher volume, and more exploitative. I also visited Paithani sari weavers separately their product, identity, and relationship to the programme were distinct, and collapsing them into one "community" would have produced bad research. By May 12 I was contributing to baseline survey instrument design the first moment TISS methods training felt directly applicable.

3.3 Digital Literacy Training: Week Three

Three consecutive sessions 50+ on May 14, 40 on May 15, 60 on May 16. Over 150 people in one week. On May 14 I followed the slide deck too closely and lost the older participants twenty minutes in. I slowed down, started asking instead of explaining, had one participant show the person next to her how to find WhatsApp. By May 16 I was running two parallel tracks: direct demonstration for beginners, peer-to-peer practice for confident users. Not planned. It came from paying attention.

One outcome not in the programme at all: Instagram product photography. A younger weaver asked whether he could reach buyers without platform fees. That turned into an afternoon on smartphone photography light, angle, background. Within days several participants were posting product images independently. Clearest evidence I had that something had actually landed.

3.4 Baseline Survey

Only 40% of weavers had heard of the GI tag almost entirely workers aged 45 and above. Roughly 70% owned smartphones, but most were used only for calls and WhatsApp. The instrument broke on day one of piloting. A question about "primary occupation" did not work for households running three income streams simultaneously. I rewrote a third of the survey before the main administration more useful than any classroom exercise.

3.5 Home Visits

The May 18 home visits were among the most valuable days of the month. Seeing a loom taking up a third of a room where a family also cooks, eats, and sleeps made informal labour concrete in a way no survey data could. The women I met at home were more candid than in group settings speaking directly about income instability and what digital tools could or could not realistically fit into their lives.

3.6 Coffee Table Book

Nine chapters covering the Chaddar, terry towels, sarees, the Padmashali community, and the bidi sector. Field photography on May 20, drafting, feedback incorporation, and a State Lead review on May 26. Writing for a general reader forces you to pay closer attention to what is actually in front of you. I think it made me a more careful fieldworker.

3.7 Suchna-preneur Field Visit

On May 23 I accompanied a Suchna-preneur to observe grassroots digital service delivery the workarounds when connectivity fails, the patience required, the negotiation between what a platform allows and what a user actually needs. More instructive than any programme document.

4. Skills and Knowledge Acquired

4.1 KoBoToolbox and Survey Design for Real Populations

I had used survey tools in academic assignments. KoBoToolbox in the field is a different experience and the difference is not the software, it is the people on the other side of it.

The baseline survey covered income sources, occupational patterns, device ownership, and GI tag awareness. On paper it looked clean. On day one of piloting it fell apart. A question about "primary occupation" assumed people had one most weaver households ran two or three income streams simultaneously. A question about monthly income prompted blank

looks from workers paid per piece. A question about "internet usage frequency" meant nothing to someone who used data only when their son topped up the SIM.

I rewrote roughly a third of the instrument before the main survey began. Sitting with a half-broken tool and figuring out why it broke taught me more about survey design than any methods class had. The principle I came away with: a question is only as good as the category it assumes, and classroom categories often assume lives that do not match the people you are actually studying.

By the end I was administering forms in two modes typed entry for those comfortable with the device, verbal recording for others. That required a judgment call in each interaction: when to hand over the phone, when to hold it myself, how to phrase the same question three different ways without leading the answer. I made that call 330+ times.

4.2 In-Depth Interviewing What It Actually Takes

The textbook version of qualitative interviewing: researcher builds rapport, asks open questions, respondent opens up. That version exists. I met it maybe a dozen times across four weeks. The rest of the time it looked like this a factory owner with seven minutes between calls answering everything in passive voice; a weaver deferring to her husband even though I had specifically asked to speak with her; a cooperative manager saying what he thought DEF wanted to hear until I stopped asking programme questions and asked about his own work history instead.

Learning to interview well is mostly learning to manage yourself: the instinct to fill silences, the temptation to rephrase when you already know the answer you want. I got better at it across the weeks. I am still not particularly good at it. But I understand now what the skill actually is less technique, more genuine patience and curiosity. Those are harder to learn than any method.

The most candid conversations were not in scheduled interviews. They happened during home visits on May 18, when I sat with handloom sari workers at their looms and asked about their day rather than their income.

4.3 Training Facilitation Learning to Read a Room

Three consecutive sessions in week three 50+, 40, and 60 participants taught me things I could not have learned from a single session or from watching someone else do it.

On May 14 I knew the content. I did not know the room. About twenty minutes in I was losing the older participants not because the content was wrong but because I was moving at the pace I had rehearsed rather than the pace the room needed. I slowed down, started asking instead of explaining, asked one participant to show the person next to her how to find WhatsApp rather than demonstrating it myself. The energy shifted.

By May 15 I had adjusted the structure less time on theoretical internet explanations, more time on WhatsApp for business, which was where questions clustered. By May 16, with sixty

participants, I was running two parallel tracks: direct demonstration for beginners, peer-to-peer practice for more confident users. That was not planned. It came from paying attention.

The Instagram product photography module was not in the programme at all. A younger weaver asked whether he could reach buyers without platform commission. That question turned into an afternoon on smartphone photography angle, lighting, background. Within days several participants were posting product images independently. It happened because I followed a question rather than a curriculum.

4.4 Participatory Observation Being Present Without an Agenda

The skill in participatory observation is mostly restraint: being in a space without constantly trying to extract something from it.

The powerloom visits on May 9 and 10 paid off precisely because I had no interview schedule I had gone to observe. What I saw was a working environment significantly different from the cooperative handloom sector: faster, louder, more mechanised, workers whose relationship with employers was purely transactional in a way cooperative members' was not. That observation shaped how I framed every subsequent interview about labour conditions. It was not data in any formal sense. It was context and context is what separates analysis from description.

The Suchna-preneur field visit on May 23 worked the same way. Watching a trained community-level digital intermediary navigate connectivity failures, platform limitations, and user anxiety told me more about last-mile digital service delivery than any programme document had.

4.5 Documentation and Writing for Different Audiences

Academic writing has a grammar: claim, evidence, qualification, citation. Development communication has a different one: scene, character, context, implication. Writing a nine-chapter coffee table book for a general reader meant describing a Chaddar production unit so that someone who has never seen a loom could picture it, while staying accurate enough that a weaver reading it would recognise their own work.

The field photography on May 20 was part of this thinking about a production space visually rather than analytically. The review meeting with DEF's State Lead on May 26 was a different skill: taking strategic feedback on a draft and incorporating it without losing the voice that made the book readable. Harder than it sounds when the feedback comes from someone with a programme stake in how the content is framed.

4.6 What the Month Built, Taken Together

I arrived with classroom knowledge of research methods and a theoretical understanding of informal economies. I am leaving with something more durable: a practical sense of when methods work and when they do not, what a community looks like from inside rather than from a literature review, and what it takes to be trusted by people who have no particular reason to trust you.

That last thing is the hardest to name as a skill. But it is what makes all the other skills work. You can design a perfect survey instrument and collect nothing if the person filling it thinks you are wasting their time. You can run a technically flawless training session and change nothing if participants leave feeling talked at. Development practice is relational before it is methodological and the relationship has to be earned.

5. Integration with Development Studies

5.1 Informality Is Not a Gap. I Saw What It Actually Is.

Before Solapur I could write a clean paragraph on informal labour Breman, Harriss-White, the NCEUS definition, the argument that informality subsidises the formal sector by externalising risk onto workers. I had written that paragraph in at least two assignments.

Then I sat in a powerloom unit on May 9 and the owner explained his workforce to me.

No contracts. No ESI. No PF. Women on piece-rate at home, no floor on the rate. He was not uncomfortable saying this. He explained it like any operational decision cheaper, simpler, this is how it works here. What stayed with me afterward was not that the exploitation existed but that it had been so thoroughly normalised it did not appear as exploitation to anyone involved.

Ananya Roy argues that informality is not a gap in regulation but produced by it through exemptions and thresholds that make informal arrangements more viable for those with power to choose. I had agreed with that in a seminar. In that powerloom unit I stopped agreeing and started understanding. Those are different things.

5.2 A Saree Takes One Week. The Contractor Takes Rs. 7,000–10,000.

On May 18 I visited a woman weaver at home. She had been working on a saree for four days and expected to finish in two more. Six days, sometimes a full week. The contractor who supplies yarn and collects the finished product pays her Rs. 5,000.

He sells it for Rs. 12,000 to 15,000.

I asked whether she knew what her sarees sold for. She said she knew her rate. She did not know the market price. A woman spending a week of her life making something does not know what it is worth to the person she makes it for. That gap is not accidental. It is how the arrangement sustains itself if she knew, she might ask questions, and the contractor has no incentive for that.

Polanyi's concept of embeddedness had made sense to me as an idea. What Solapur showed was how it works in reverse: the piece-rate arrangement is embedded in a social structure contractor dependency, caste-based occupational inheritance, the Padmashali community's migrant position that makes the arrangement feel natural rather than chosen. She did not say she was being exploited. She said Rs. 5,000 was the rate. That is what Polanyi means when

he says fictitious commodification does social damage. It does not only take money. It takes the ability to imagine things being different.

5.3 Participation The Word and the Reality

Chambers spent decades arguing that interventions fail because they are designed by outsiders for communities who were not asked. Digikargha is described as community-centred and the intent is real. But the programme was designed before the community was consulted, because it had to be written before the grant existed. By the time I arrived, modules were fixed, schedules were fixed, deliverables were fixed.

I noticed this most clearly around timing. Multiple weavers mentioned during home visits that daytime sessions were hard to attend. A few said evenings would have worked better. A ten-minute conversation during programme design could have caught that. Nobody had it.

Cornwall wrote about the gap between participatory language and information delivery. I had read it as theoretical critique. In Solapur it looked like weavers sitting through sessions timed for the programme's convenience, being counted as beneficiaries in a report I would never see.

5.4 Seventy Percent Had Smartphones. Almost None Could Use Them for Work.

The baseline survey showed 70% smartphone ownership encouraging on the surface. Then I spent a week talking to those owners.

One woman had owned a smartphone for three years. She used it to receive calls from her son in Pune. When I asked why nothing else, the answer was immediate: data costs money she does not reliably have, she would not know what to do if something went wrong on a platform, and she has no spare time to figure out something new that might not pay off.

Sen's capability approach distinguishes between having a resource and having the substantive freedom to use it. A smartphone is a means. Using it commercially requires affordable data, confidence, time, and institutional backup if something goes wrong. Remove any one and the phone stays in a pocket. The Solapur data made that distinction concrete in a way that reading Sen in a classroom had not.

5.5 The GI Tag Works. Just Not for the Weavers.

Forty percent of weavers had heard of the GI tag on the Solapur Chaddar. The 60% who had not were mostly younger workers the people who will be weaving Chaddars for the next thirty years.

I asked a factory owner whether the GI tag changed how he priced for export buyers. He said yes, it helped justify a premium. I asked whether that reached the weavers. He said the rate was the rate.

The legal instrument works. The premium exists. A certification designed to benefit producers is being used by intermediaries to capture better prices, which stay with the

intermediary. The weaver spending a week on one saree receives Rs. 5,000. The GI tag gave the factory owner a better argument with buyers. It did not change what she was paid.

5.6 The Livelihoods Framework As a Live Diagnostic

In Solapur I stopped using the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework as a coursework tool and started using it to understand what I was actually looking at.

Human capital: high in craft skill, near-zero in digital. That gap is Digikargha's entry point and it is real.

Financial capital: almost none. Piece-rate income, no savings buffer, credit only through moneylenders or contractor advances. When a loom breaks, a family borrows. The contractor who lends usually extracts it through the next consignment.

Social capital: split. Within the Padmashali community Telugu-speaking migrants from Andhra and Telangana it is strong. Between the community and formal institutions, it is thin and nearly always mediated by a contractor who positions himself as the necessary bridge. That mediation maintains information asymmetry and dependency simultaneously.

The framework makes one thing visible that matters for Digikargha: digital skills are being built in a community where financial capital is the more immediate binding constraint. If you cannot afford consistent data, cannot wait sixty days for a marketplace payment, and cannot absorb a disputed consignment, the digital skill does not convert into income.

5.7 What Triangulation Looks Like When It Is Not an Exercise

The survey told me 70% owned smartphones. Interviews told me most phones were used only for calls. Home visits showed me the physical and time conditions that explained why. Three methods, three layers together they told a story that was true rather than technically accurate. The survey number alone would have led me to a completely wrong conclusion about the community's digital readiness.

Focus groups with women weavers produced different material from individual interviews with the same women. In the group: shorter, more careful answers shaped by who else was in the room. Alone: direct answers about debt, actual income, what they really thought of the training. I had read that group and individual settings surface different aspects of experience. In Solapur I ran both with the same people in the same week and the difference was not subtle it was the difference between a managed answer and an honest one.

The participatory observation produced no formal data. What it produced was the context that made all other data interpretable. Without standing in that powerloom unit, survey responses about labour conditions were just numbers. Methods training taught me what the tools are. Solapur taught me what they are for.

6. Relevance for Career Development

I came into this internship with a general sense of what I wanted to do something in development, something field-grounded, something that did not involve sitting in an office producing reports nobody would read. I left with something more specific.

My career interests sit across four areas: livelihoods, urban development, environmental justice, and digital empowerment of workers. Before Solapur, these felt like separate tracks I had not yet chosen between. The internship showed me they are not separate at all. The weaver community in Solapur is a livelihoods question, an urban informality question, and a digital inclusion question simultaneously. You cannot work seriously on any one of them without bumping into the others.

On livelihoods work specifically, this internship gave me tools I did not have before. KoBoToolbox, baseline survey design, in-depth interviews, focus group facilitation, participatory observation I have used all of them now in a real setting, with real stakes, with a population that did not owe me their time or their honest answers. That is a different kind of credential from a methods course. Organisations working on artisan livelihoods, informal labour, or rural income whether NGOs, CSR foundations, or research institutions run on exactly this kind of field data capacity. I can now do that work rather than just describe how it should be done.

On urban development, the Solapur experience deepened something I had been thinking about since my coursework on urban informality. Cities like Solapur mid-size, industrial, built on sectors that are simultaneously formal and deeply informal are where a large part of India's development story actually happens, and they are chronically under-researched compared to metros. The powerloom visits, the home visits in weaver clusters, the cooperative meetings all of it built a concrete understanding of how urban informal economies function, who holds power within them, and where institutional interventions tend to land. That understanding is directly useful for roles in urban livelihoods research, city-level programme management, or policy work on the informal sector.

On digital empowerment of workers, I now have direct programme experience. I designed and delivered digital literacy training for over 150 people in a single week. I adapted content in real time, built an unplanned Instagram photography module from a single participant question, and administered a baseline survey that will feed into programme monitoring. For organisations working on digital inclusion DEF itself, or others working on similar last-mile digital access programmes this is not generic experience. It is specific and demonstrable.

On environmental justice, this internship did not address it directly. But it reinforced something the environmental justice literature argues consistently: that the communities most exposed to environmental risk are almost always the same communities that are economically marginalised, institutionally ignored, and digitally excluded. The weavers of Solapur working in dusty, poorly ventilated units, with no occupational health protection sit at that intersection. Understanding how marginalisation works in one domain makes you better at recognising it in others.

What the month in Solapur clarified most was the kind of development professional I want to be. Not a specialist who works in one sector and knows nothing about the adjacent ones. Someone who can move between livelihoods, technology, urban systems, and rights-based frameworks without losing the thread connecting them which is always, at the bottom, the question of who has power and who does not.

7. Critical Reflection

7.1 The Institutional Support Is Thinner Than It Looks

The weavers' union in Solapur was historically significant. It is not anymore. By the time I arrived it had almost no influence over wages or working conditions. Cooperatives exist, but several are effectively run by factory owners. In that environment, teaching someone to use Flipkart hits a wall digital participation means very little without the collective power to negotiate the terms of it.

One woman I worked with understood e-commerce clearly after two sessions product listings, GI tag pricing, UPI payments. She could explain all of it. She also had no bank account in her own name, her household data ran out before the end of most months, and she had no spare time between weaving quotas and running a household. The programme's logic was sound. The conditions needed to act on it were not there. That gap between a well-designed intervention and the reality it lands in is what I kept coming back to all month.

7.2 Attendance Is Not Participation

Not everyone came because they wanted to. Some came because a neighbour was going. Some were curious about what DEF was doing. Some had nothing else that morning. A few, I think, came for the chai.

That is fine. That is how community programmes work. But it matters for what attendance numbers actually mean.

The honest conversations happened outside formal sessions over tea after a workshop, during home visits, walking between production units. Nobody was performing in those moments. That is where people told me what they actually thought, what they were genuinely curious about, and what they were realistically going to do with what they had learned. For several of them: not much yet. Not because the training failed. Because the surrounding conditions were not ready for it.

7.3 One Programme Cannot Fix a Multi-Dimensional Problem

This is not a criticism of DEF. It is a pattern across development programming in India multi-dimensional vulnerability addressed through single-sector, time-bound interventions. A digital literacy programme here, a credit scheme somewhere else, a GI awareness drive whenever funding arrives. Each running independently, none coordinated.

The weaver community's situation is shaped by labour law gaps, financial exclusion, weak collective bargaining, and thin market infrastructure. A month of digital training does not change most of that. It may genuinely improve things for households that engage seriously and that is worth something. But development organisations should be more honest about what a single intervention can and cannot do. The ones I respect most are the ones that say it plainly.

7.4 On Being an Outsider

My position was simple on the surface: the person from the NGO who came to teach digital tools. That framing worked. Weavers were warm and, once trust was established, genuinely open. Telling them I was an MA student doing an internship seemed to help it made things feel less institutional.

Factory owners were different. At least one made clear, without quite saying it, that NGO presence made him uncomfortable because he associated it with labour mobilisation. He was not wrong. The conditions in his unit piece-rate, no social security, women workers without contracts were exactly what a labour rights organisation would find actionable. I was there to teach Instagram. But his wariness told me something real about how factory owners in this sector read NGO presence and why certain doors stay closed.

The Padmashali community was the most unexpected challenge. Telugu-speaking migrants from Andhra and Telangana, first language not Marathi. My Marathi and Hindi worked with most of the broader community. With the Padmashali groups I relied more on demonstrations and bilingual community members who could bridge the gap. It was a reminder that the community was never one thing Solapur's weavers carry histories of migration, caste, and regional identity that no amount of language preparation fully accounts for.

8. Conclusion

The month in Solapur was the most educationally dense I have had since starting at TISS, and the most humbling.

DEF's work is genuinely useful. The training sessions reached real people. The Instagram photography module produced something weavers used independently. The Suchna-preneur model points toward something more sustainable than periodic external workshops. These are not small things.

But the scope of any single programme is narrow compared to what the structural situation requires. That is not DEF's failure. It is how development programming is funded and evaluated in India, and the gap between what programmes promise and what structures allow is something the sector does not talk about honestly enough.

Three things I am taking forward.

Fieldwork is relational before it is methodological. The quality of what you learn depends on the trust you build, and trust takes longer than project timelines allow.

Digital tools are not inherently empowering. Whether they help anyone depends on what else is in place financial access, collective organisation, time, confidence. Those conditions come from political economy, not training workshops.

The most honest writing I did was for the coffee table book, where I had no programme logic to satisfy. That taught me the difference between writing that serves an institution and writing that serves the people it is about. The kind of development professional I want to be is one who can do both and knows which one is needed when.

Appendix: Photographs

digital literacy training sessions *(May 14–16),*

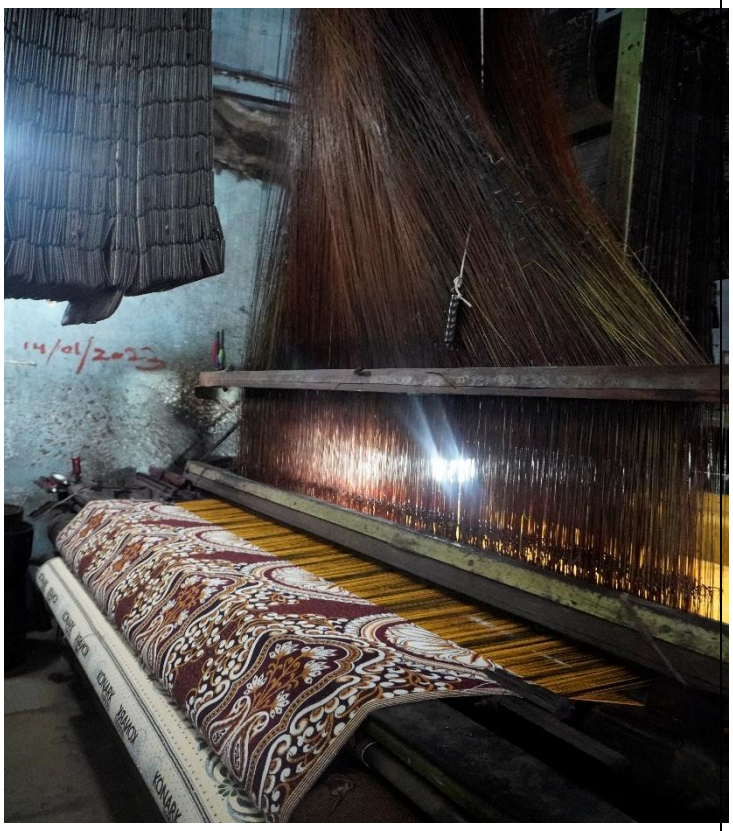




























CHADAR MOTIF AND DESIGN:













Paithani sari:

